

You wrote the whole explanation, and they read the first line

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · cheatgrid.com

Part of why you wrote it all out was so you could point back later and say you explained it. That **doesn't mean anyone read past your first line**, and writing it more carefully won't fix that.

THE GOAL

Put the one thing they need to know or do in your first sentence. Write everything after it **for someone who might not get there**.

CHECKLIST

You're staring at a draft with more than one thing to say, deciding what goes first and what can wait.

- ☐ Write down **the one thing** they need to know or do, separately from your draft.
- ☐ If you can't cut what you need to say to a couple of sentences, that's a sign this needs a conversation, not writing.
- ☐ Put the one thing they need to know or do in your very first sentence, spelling out any number, date or amount tied to it.
- ☐ Read your first sentence alone. If it doesn't make sense without anything else around it, rewrite it before you touch the rest.
- ☐ Move your background, setup or reasoning to after the point, never before it.
- ☐ When you cut the draft down, make sure what's left still names what this message is replying to or about.
- ☐ Give each idea beyond your main point its own short paragraph or heading, separate from the ones beside it.
- ☐ If you have more than a handful of separate points, sort them into a couple of named groups instead of one long list.
- ☐ Put the single most time-sensitive detail on its own short line, not folded into the middle of a paragraph.
- ☐ If you're asking for something, add one short reason in the same sentence instead of a bare request.
- ☐ If you still want to add 'just in case' detail, put it after the main point, in a short line of its own.
- ☐ If you can, show your first sentence to one other person and ask **what they think it means**, before you send it.
- ☐ Reread only your first sentence and your last one before you send it.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Don't trust a careful reread to catch what will confuse someone else.
- 2** A heading only lifts memory for **the words sitting right under it**.
- 3** The longer a message is, the more likely it gets set aside instead of read now. In a workplace study, people left long messages sitting unread or half-read far more often than short ones.

What happens once you hit send

RULE

Half your explanation gets read only if the whole thing runs under about 110 words.

Add length past that and the share you have time to read keeps falling, often to around a fifth on an ordinary page. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Attention on a page doesn't spread evenly. In an eye-tracking study of people reading web pages, the second horizontal scan already covered less width than the first, before attention narrowed into a strip down the left. So a point placed early but off to the right can still sit outside what a reader actually sees. [Source 2](#)

Why checking it yourself doesn't catch it

KNOW

You will likely believe your explanation landed better than it did. Writers in a study expected readers to understand their point 63 to 74 percent of the time, but only 48 to 51 percent did, even after a full revision. Revising the draft did not close this gap. In the same study, it grew slightly wider instead. [Source 3](#)

DON'T

Don't trust a careful reread to catch what will confuse someone else.

Unlike a conversation, a reader can't ask you questions, so nothing outside your own head corrects what you meant. [Source 3](#)

DO

Ask a real reader what they understood before you write something similar again. In a study, writers given just a single number, no comments at all, went on to write clearer descriptions than writers given no feedback.

The number shows you exactly where your sense of what's clear and what a reader gets **have come apart**. [Source 4](#)

What earns a place in the part that gets read

KNOW

A heading only lifts memory for **the words sitting right under it**.

The review measured memory, not attention: it says whether signals actually redirect attention is still an open question. [Source 5](#)

KNOW

The longer a message is, the more likely it gets set aside instead of read now. In a workplace study, people left long messages sitting unread or half-read far more often than short ones.

Length itself takes more time and effort, so it gets set aside like anything that doesn't fit the time a reader has free right then. [Source 6](#)

DON'T

Don't cut the line that says what you're replying to, even when trimming hard.

In a study, a coworker's one-line replies left a colleague unable to tell what he even meant. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

List around seven points and most readers will hold onto every one while they read the rest.

ACTUALLY

The most careful estimates put real short-term capacity at **three to five items, not seven**, so more than a handful gets pushed out before the reader finishes your list. [Source 7](#)

Sources

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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Writing so people read it at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)